Advent Sermon Series: Prepare the Way

Making Room for the Coming of Christ

Series Theme:
Advent is a season of preparation. We prepare our homes, our calendars, and our celebrations—but Scripture calls us to prepare something deeper: **our hearts and our lives for the coming of Christ.** Through the prophets, we discover that God meets us in our longing, comforts us in our weariness, restores what is broken, shines light into our darkness, and gives us joy in his presence.

NOTE: I have chosen to switch the Old Testament reading from the Lectionary for Week 4, to keep the whole series in Isaiah.

Week 1 — Prepare the Way for God to Come

Isaiah 64:1–9

Theme: Longing for God

Main Idea: Sometimes preparing the way begins simply by admitting how desperately we need God.

Isaiah's prayer is raw and honest: *"O that you would tear open the heavens and come down!"* The people are longing for God to intervene in a world that feels broken and distant from him.

Possible sermon points:

- We prepare the way by acknowledging our need.
- We can bring our honest questions and disappointments to God.
- Even when we feel far from God, we belong to the God who is shaping us.

Advent emphasis: Hope

Key phrase:

"Prepare the way by making room for our longing for God."

Week 2 — Prepare the Way with Comfort

Isaiah 40:1–11

Theme: God comes to weary people

Main Idea: God prepares the way by bringing comfort to people who are weary, discouraged, and waiting.

Isaiah's message changes dramatically: *"Comfort, O comfort my people."* The voice announces that God is coming—and his coming changes everything.

Possible sermon points:

- God speaks comfort into our weariness.
- God makes a way where there seems to be no way.
- The coming King is both powerful and tender.

The beautiful image of verse 11 could become the heart of the sermon:
"He will feed his flock like a shepherd; he will gather the lambs in his arms."

Advent emphasis: Peace

Key phrase:

"Prepare the way by allowing God's comfort to meet you in your weariness."

Week 3 — Prepare the Way for Restoration

Isaiah 61:1–4, 8–11

Theme: Good news for the broken

Main Idea: The coming of God's Anointed One brings good news, healing, freedom, and restoration.

This passage gives us a picture of God's mission: good news to the poor, healing for the brokenhearted, freedom for captives, and rebuilding what has been devastated.

Jesus later identifies himself with this mission in Luke 4.

Possible sermon points:

- Christ comes to bring good news.
- Christ meets us in places of brokenness.
- God doesn't simply repair what is broken—he makes it beautiful again.
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Verse 3 gives you a powerful image for Advent:

"The oil of gladness instead of mourning."

Advent emphasis: Restoration / Joy

Key phrase:

"Prepare the way by believing that God can bring beauty out of brokenness."

Week 4 — Prepare the Way for the Light

Isaiah 9:1–7

Theme: Light in the darkness

Main Idea: When darkness seems overwhelming, God promises the coming of a light that cannot be extinguished.

This is one of Advent's most recognizable prophetic passages:
"The people who walked in darkness have seen a great light."

The promised child comes as **Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace.**

Possible sermon points:

- God sees us in the darkness.
- God's light doesn't wait for the darkness to disappear.
- The child who comes brings a different kind of kingdom.
- Christ's peace is stronger than the chaos around us.

Advent emphasis: Love / Light

Key phrase:

"Prepare the way by looking for the light of Christ, even in the darkness."

Christmas Sunday — Prepare the Way with Joy

Isaiah 61:10–62:3

Theme: Rejoicing in what God is doing

Main Idea: Those who have experienced God's salvation cannot help but rejoice—and God's people become a visible testimony to his faithfulness.

The passage moves from mourning to celebration:

"I will greatly rejoice in the LORD; my whole being shall exult in my God."

The imagery of clothing, a bride and bridegroom, a flourishing garden, and a shining crown makes this a beautiful conclusion to the series.

Possible sermon points:

- God's salvation gives us a reason to rejoice.
- God is still at work, even when we cannot yet see the finished picture.
- God's people are meant to shine as witnesses to his faithfulness.
- The coming of Christ changes our identity.

Key phrase:

"Prepare the way by making room for the joy of God's salvation."

Series Arc

Week	Passage	Sermon Title	Theme
1	Isaiah 64:1–9	**Prepare the Way for God to Come**	Hope
2	Isaiah 40:1–11	**Prepare the Way with Comfort**	Peace
3	Isaiah 61:1–4, 8–11	**Prepare the Way for Restoration**	Restoration / Joy
4	Isaiah 9:1–7	**Prepare the Way for the Light**	Light / Love
	Isaiah 61:10–62:3	**Prepare the Way with Joy**	Returning to Joy

A simple series progression:

Longing → Comfort → Restoration → Light → Joy

And the overarching message could be:

Advent is more than preparing for Christmas. It is preparing our hearts for the Christ who comes to meet us in our longing, comfort us in our weariness, restore what is broken, shine light into our darkness, and fill us with joy.

Series tagline

PREPARE THE WAY
Make room for the One who is coming.